the battle, but they were soon in danger themselves. Subedar Dhan Bahadur Chand had to cover their withdrawal with a LMG.

One last bid to dislodge the milling Chinese at Charlie Company was made by the adjutant; Major Shrikent had managed to collect a dozen men and he tried to go to Dogra's aid. It was hopeless, however, and soon this party was hemmed in from all sides as the company position had more or less been overrun. Somehow, Shrikent managed to break off contact and pull his party out.

Two hours after the first mortar bombs had rained down from the sky, Charlie Company of 1/9 GR ceased to exist and the Chinese now turned their full attention towards Alpha Company and Battalion HQ. A large force had got above and behind the Gorkhas, and this group began to close the gap with Battalion HQ. The Gorkhas were fighting desperately and all the news trickling into the command post was negative. Subedar Jit Bahadur and the thirty men who had gone to reinforce Charlie Company had also been encircled and overwhelmed. Two other officers, Second Lieutenant Mahindra and Captain Mahabir Prasad had been wounded and were missing. Captain Prasad, who was from 1 Sikh and had set up the Assam Rifles post at Dhola, had been attached to 1/9 GR on 4 October. As the fighting around the command post intensified, Ahluwalia had been shot in the right shoulder. Realizing the futility of prolonging the battle, Ahluwalia ordered his remaining officers and troops to pull out and withdraw from Tsangdhar.

That the Gorkhas managed to break contact at all was an achievement of sorts, but in the melee, the withdrawal was confused and disorganized. While the bulk of the men withdrew with Ahluwalia towards the Tsangdhar drop zone, a second lot got separated and took the track down towards Bridge 2, but got only as far as Brigade HQ. The CO was carried in a makeshift stretcher constructed with a couple of rifles and a blanket but it was obvious that he was in terrible pain and in urgent need of medical attention. The surviving Gorkhas had just about got past the Delta Company defences on the ridgeline at Tsangdhar, when the Chinese started their assault on Subedar Harka Bahadur's platoon that was defending the ridge. Ahluwalia further split his group, telling his adjutant, Major Shrikent, to deploy some men and help hold the ridge.

The Chinese assault on the Tsangdhar Ridge began to gain momentum. With his ammunition dwindling, Harka Bahadur with about a dozen